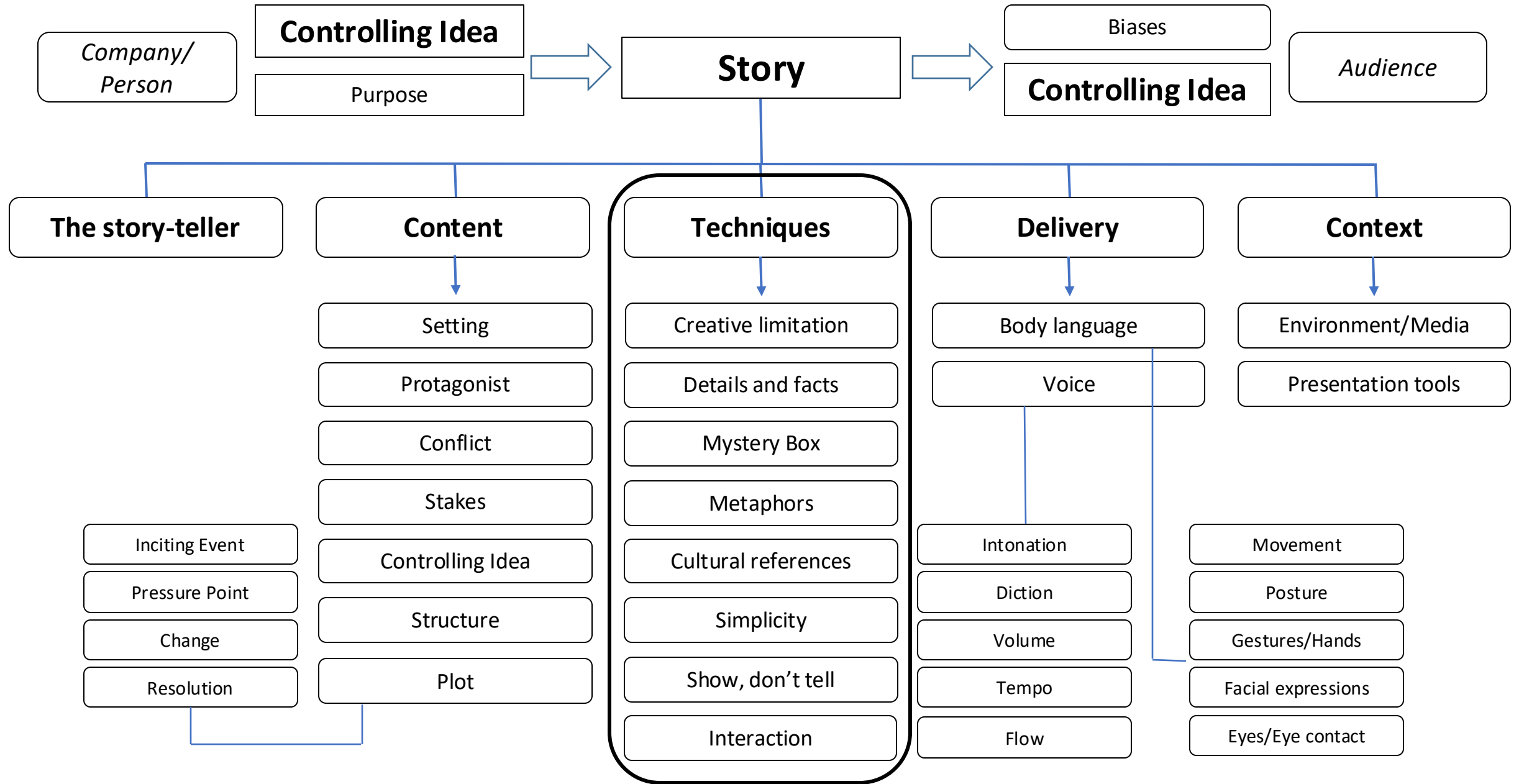


Storytelling techniques



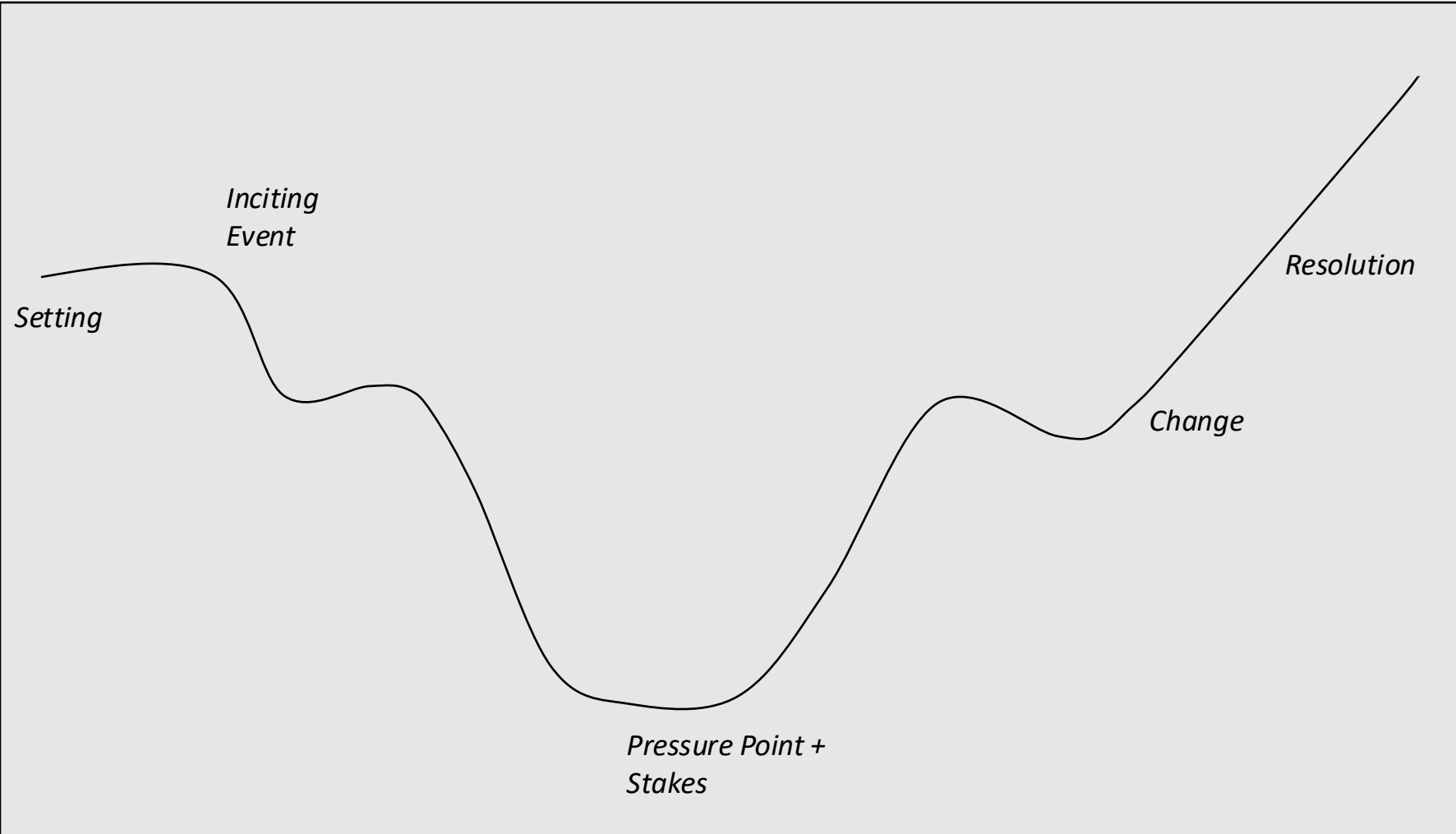
Story Headline

Purpose:
WIIFM?

The Audience
Who are they?
WIIFT?
Beliefs

Controlling Idea

Protagonist
Antagonist
Conflict



Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

Creative limitation

The principle of creative limitation

- The constraints that the setting imposes on story design don't inhibit creativity – they inspire it
- No matter how grand a fictional world may seem, a closer look reveals it's small – sometimes remarkably so

The life story of every character
offers endless possibilities.
The mark of a master story teller
is to show only a few moments –
but give us **a glimpse of a lifetime**

Examples

Focusing on:

- One specific management discussion
- One specific project
- One client, in one specific situation
- One specific sale
- Etc.

Every story is trying to create
something **universal** out of the **very specific**

Sometimes all it takes
is **one** scene

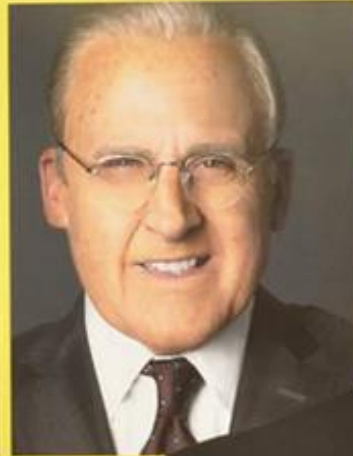
Tell me the story here...

6 GOLDEN GLOBE® NOMINATIONS | **BEST PICTURE** | **BEST DIRECTOR** | **BEST ACTOR**

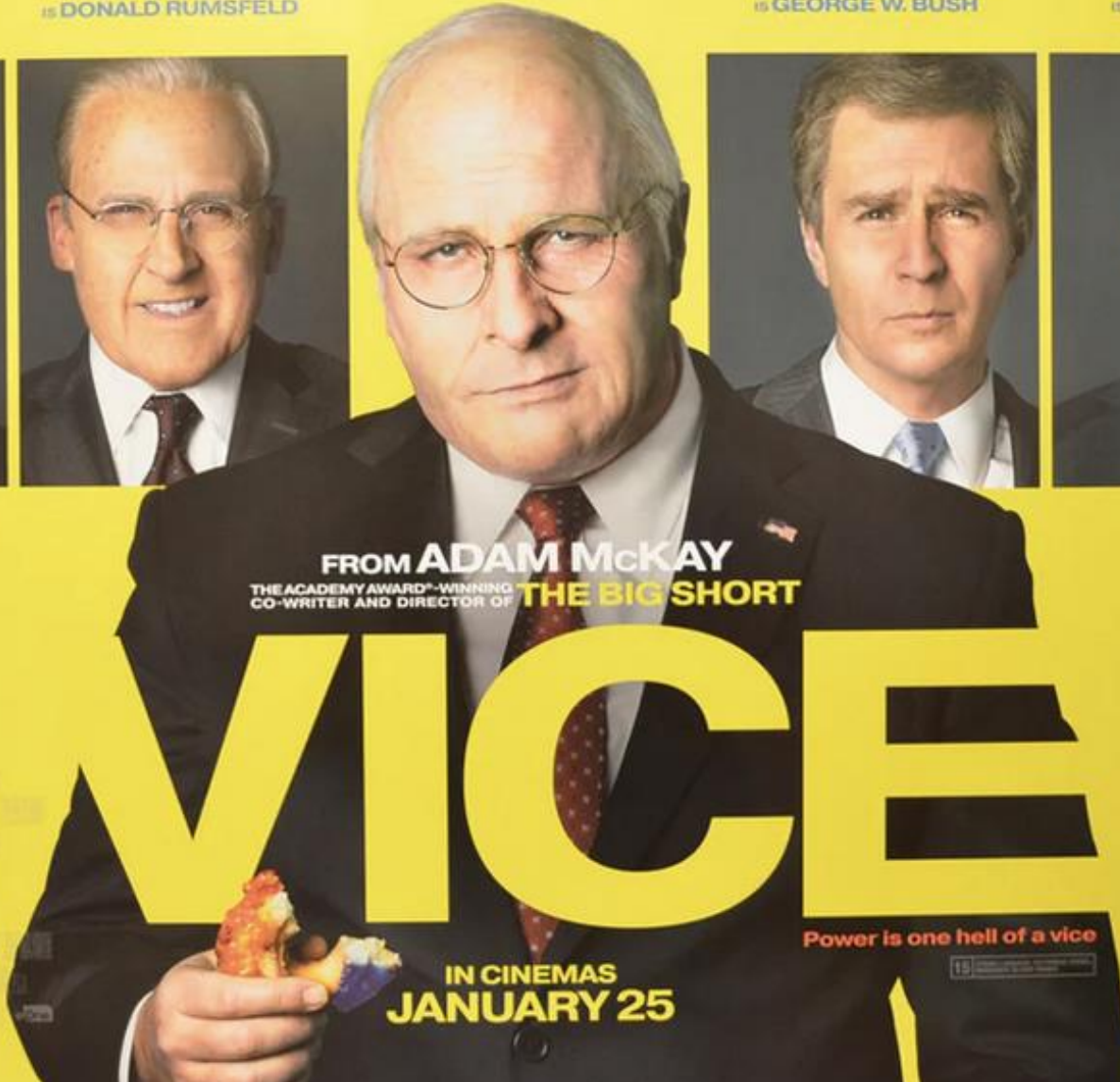
**AMY
ADAMS**
IS LYNNE CHENEY



**STEVE
CARELL**
IS DONALD RUMSFELD



**CHRISTIAN
BALE**
IS DICK CHENEY



**SAM
ROCKWELL**
IS GEORGE W. BUSH



**TYLER
PERRY**
IS COLIN POWELL



FROM ADAM MCKAY
THE ACADEMY AWARD®-WINNING
CO-WRITER AND DIRECTOR OF **THE BIG SHORT**

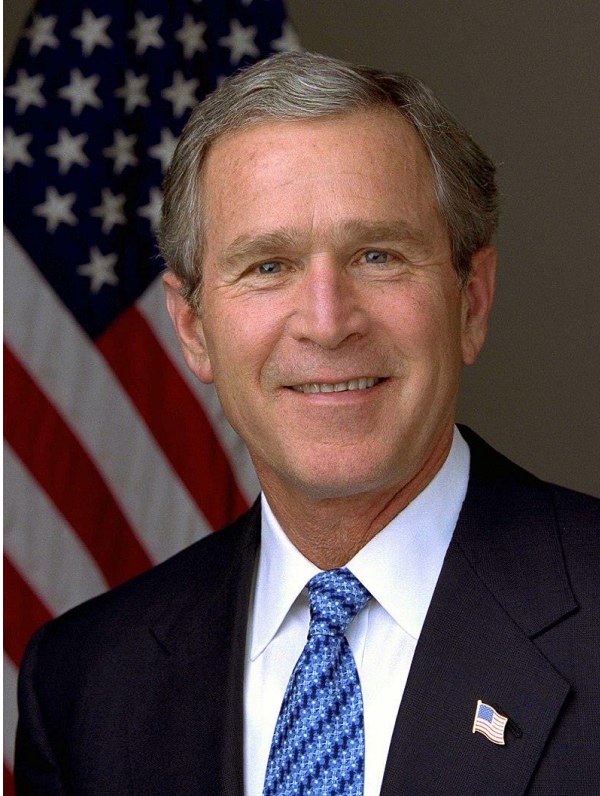
VICE

IN CINEMAS
JANUARY 25

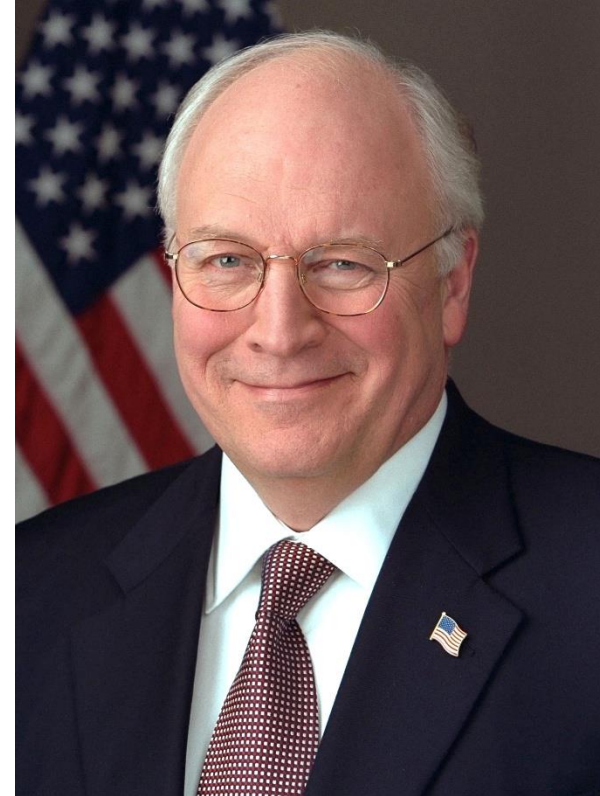
Power is one hell of a vice

15

Setting the scene for the first example: Discussing the role of Vice President



George W. Bush
The 43rd president (2000-2008)



Dick Cheney
Politician and businessman





Think:

On which **specific** moments or situations should you focus?

The Power of Creative Limitation

Rule of Thumb: One scene. One hour. One dilemma.

Why Limit:

- Increases intensity
- Focuses on emotional truth
- Avoids wandering or vague summary

Creative Limitation

Choose One or Two Key Scenes

7.1. Find the Moment of No Return

Look for the irreversible moment after which your world shifted.

Example: A key meeting where a client pulled a project, and you knew things would never go back.

7.2. Zoom in on a Room

Ask: *If I could only tell the story through one room, which one would it be?*

Example: A hotel hallway after failing to close a deal, sitting alone and rethinking everything.

7.3. Choose a Moment with Real Dialogue

Scenes come alive when real words are spoken.

Example: A colleague says, “We’re losing faith in you,” and you realize you have to rebuild trust.

7.4. Pick a Scene Where a Value Was Tested

Moments when you had to decide between easy and right.

Example: You refuse to backdate a contract under pressure from your boss.

7.5. Include Physical Action or Symbolism

Scenes are not just emotional—they’re physical.

Example: Closing your laptop in frustration, or crumpling up the speech you had rehearsed.

Creative Limitation

Choose One or Two Key Scenes

7.6. Look for Scenes with Tension, Not Just Emotion

It's not enough to feel bad—there needs to be push and pull.

Example: A fierce debate with your partner about whether to pivot your startup.

7.7. Ask: Where Was I Most Afraid or Most Alive?

Strong scenes live at emotional extremes.

Example: The moment you hit "send" on an email resigning from a secure job to pursue a risky idea.

7.8. Dramatize the Change in Your Arc

Find the moment where the "old you" cracked and the "new you" emerged.

Example: After a bitter failure, you sit in your car and realize you've been chasing the wrong success.

7.9. Set a Creative Limitation: One Hour, One Space, One Obstacle

Force focus by imposing limits.

Example: One hour before a big client pitch, trapped in an elevator, practicing your lines.

7.10. End with a Gesture, Line, or Beat That Echoes the Controlling Idea

Example: After months of struggle, you sign a partnership agreement and simply say, "This time, we do it right."

6 Examples of Creative Limitation in Business Stories

1. The Elevator Scene

Pitch deck forgotten. Elevator stuck. Rehearsing pitch aloud to metal panel.

2. The Quiet Car Call

You call your spouse in a train car, whispering: “It’s over. They said no. I don’t know what to do.”

3. The Empty Office at Midnight

Everyone’s gone. You reread the rejection email. You open a new doc and start over.

4. The Whiteboard Moment

Instead of a lecture, you walk to the board and write: “What did *we* miss?”

5. The Bathroom Mirror

Before your first keynote, you stand in front of the mirror, whispering the first line over and over.

6. The Deleted Draft

You wrote a resignation email. Then deleted it. And made a different decision.

Details and facts

Anything conceptual, abstract
or generic must be made
tangible and specific
in the protagonist's struggle

Don't talk about a “person” –
describe him or her in detail

e.g., instead of “tall man” indicate the height (6'5")

Don't talk about an event – describe it in detail

e.g., specific dates, weather etc.

When to Use Dialogue in a Story

- 1.To Create Conflict Between Characters
- 2.To Reveal Character Under Pressure
- 3.To Advance the Story Through Action
- 4.To Deliver Subtext and Emotional Tension
- 5.To Give Characters Unique, Authentic Voices

Focus on feelings, not jargon

Facts, figures and even graphs
can be used – but should be
seamlessly weaved into your story

Let's see a couple of examples



Remember:
Data is debated.
Stories are shared.

Creative limitation

Details and facts

Mystery Box

Metaphors

Cultural references

Simplicity

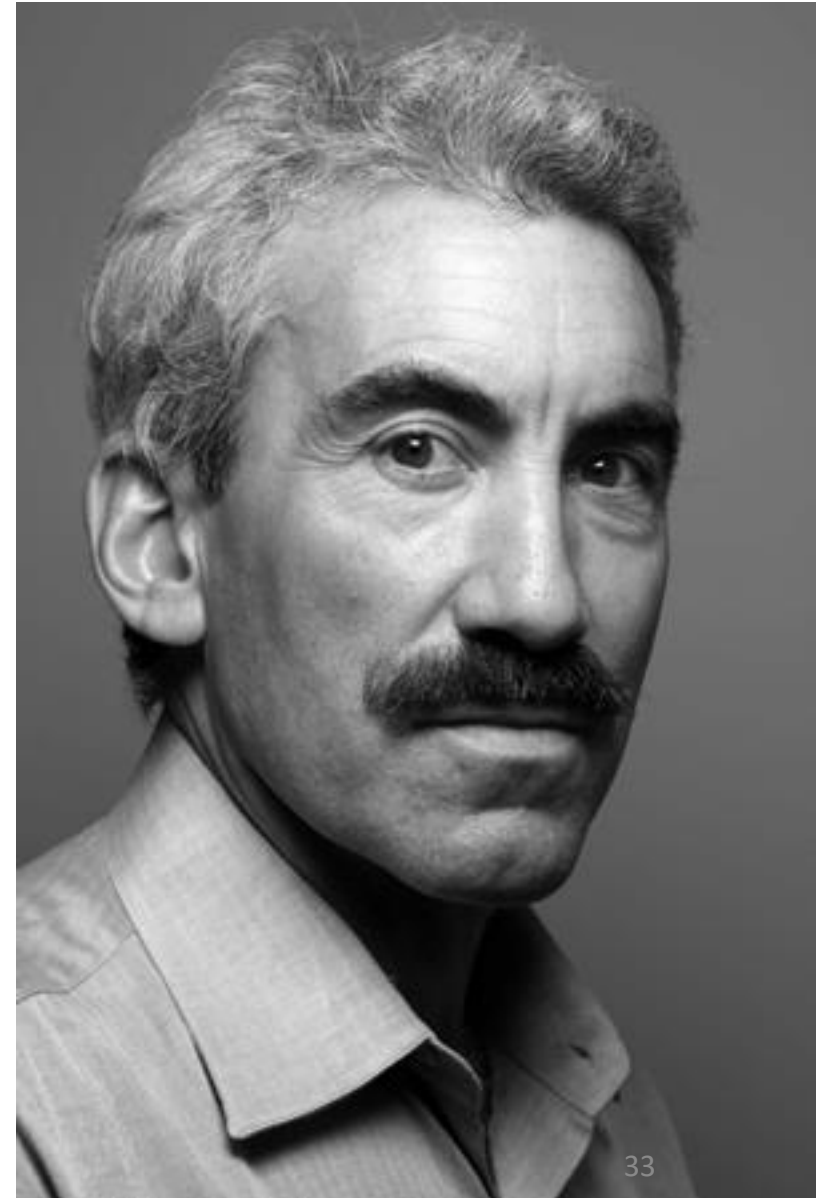
Show, don't tell

Interaction

Mystery Box

The Information Gap Theory of Curiosity

Curiosity “happens” (i.e., is aroused)
when we feel a gap in our knowledge



...and gaps cause (mental) pain –
an itch you have to scratch

Curiosity = the intellectual need
to answer questions
and close open patterns

Story plays to this universal desire by starting with **the opposite**:
posing questions and opening situations
(often closing them at the end)

“You love it
because you don’t hear it”

The Principle of Withdrawal of Information

How to open Gaps of Curiosity

- Open with an intriguing statement
 - *“I’ve never been so ashamed in my life”*
- Allude to the future
 - *“I did not realize it at that moment, but I was going to regret that choice”*
 - *“Nothing could have prepared me for what came after”*
- Use superlatives when describing other characters
 - *“She was the strongest person in that company”*
- Add a new character in the middle of the story
 - *“The CEO got ousted. Then a new one came in. Then things changed”*
- Pivot – change direction
 - *“After dedicating myself for years to being the best lawyer, I started having doubts”*

Think:
What Mystery Boxes should you
put in front your audience?

Creative limitation

Details and facts

Mystery Box

Metaphors

Cultural references

Simplicity

Show, don't tell

Interaction

Metaphors

If a picture is worth 1000
words, then a metaphor is
worth 1000 pictures

Scarlett is like the sun

VS.

Scarlett is the sun

The difference between analogies and metaphors

Metaphor = a figure of speech
in which a word or phrase is
applied to an object or action to
which it is not literally applicable

Metaphors

- Have any of you ever climbed the ladder to success?
- Have you bootstrapped your start-up?
- Did you witness a start-up go under?
- Have you ever drowned in paperwork?
- Did you burn the midnight oil?
- Have you encountered an 800-pound gorilla in your industry?
- Did you address the elephant in the room?
- Have you hammered the differences with colleagues?



Sample metaphors from MLK's speech [later in the clip]

- Let us not seek to satisfy our **thirst for freedom** by drinking from the **cup of bitterness and hatred**
- Now is the time to rise from **the dark and desolate valley of segregation** to the **sunlit path of racial justice**
- I have a dream that one day the state of Mississippi, a desert state, **sweltering with the heat of injustice and oppression**, will be transformed into an **oasis of freedom and justice**
- No, no, we are not satisfied, and we will not be satisfied until **justice rolls down like waters and righteousness like a mighty stream**

Spot the metaphor

**Bloomberg
Businessweek**

May 6, 2019



Satya Nadella, CEO

The Miracle of Microsoft

*The greatest tech company
of the 1990s is back!*

**Bloomberg
Businessweek**

March 18, 2019

**The Apology
Machine**

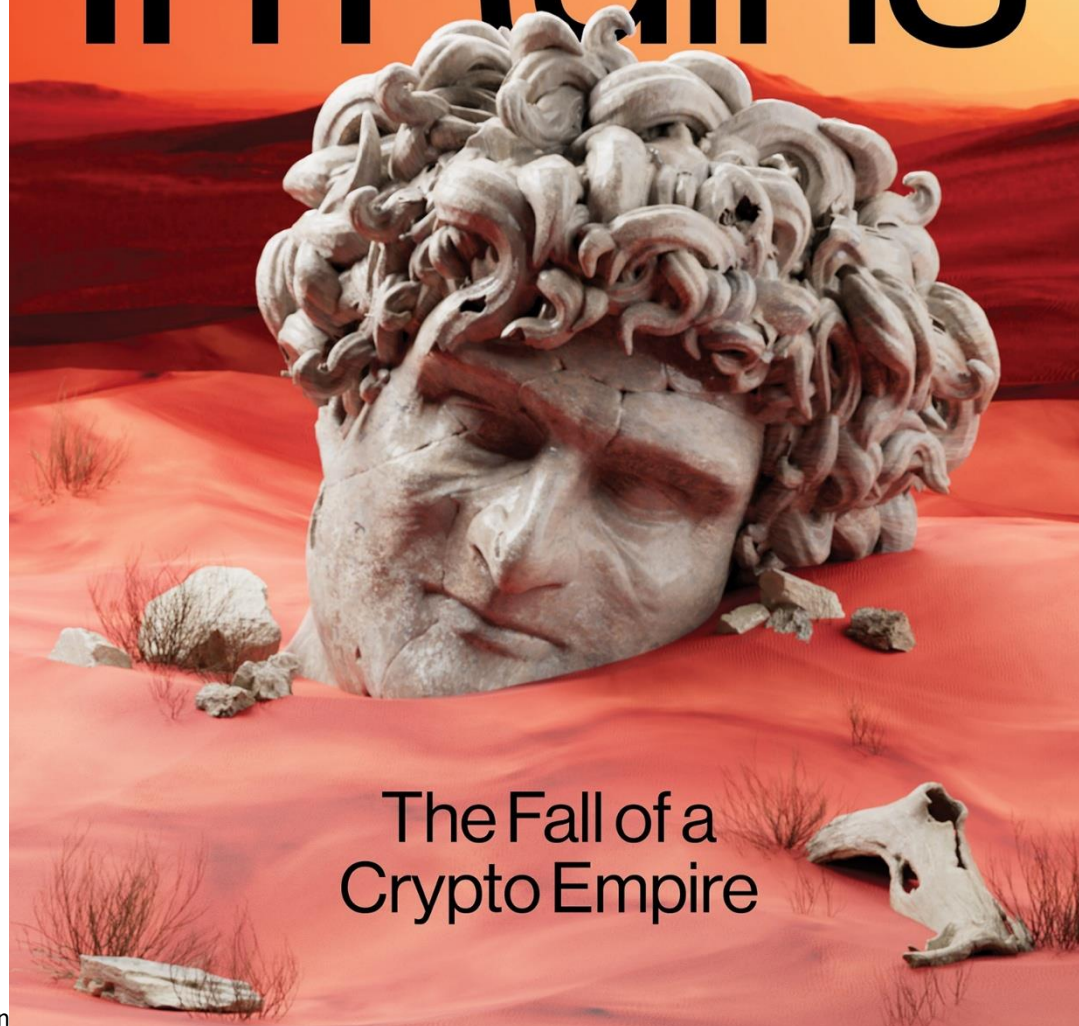
Facebook says it cares.
Is that enough?

```
switch (publicApology) {  
  case 'empathetic':  
    setVision()  
    .makeEyeContact();  
  
    delay()  
    .then(() => {  
      speak('I AM SORRY');  
    })  
  
    coreTemp(currentCoreTemp * 1.05);  
  
    ductControl()  
    .tears(2)  
    .delay()  
    .then(() => {  
      wipeTear();  
    });  
  
    return null;  
  default:  
    return userHarvest({  
      version: '6772b3',  
    });  
}
```


**Bloomberg
Businessweek**

November 21, 2022 • DOUBLE ISSUE

In Ruins



The Fall of a
Crypto Empire

Dismantling An Icon

General
Electric's
leaders
explain
why three
companies
are better
than one





Bloomberg Businessweek

February 2025

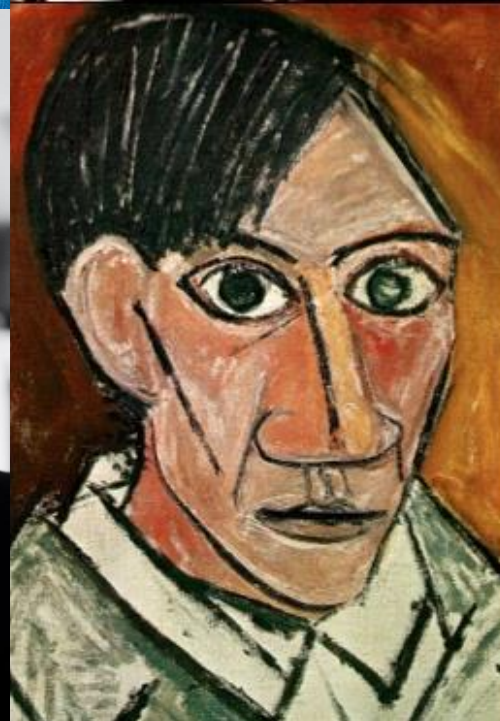
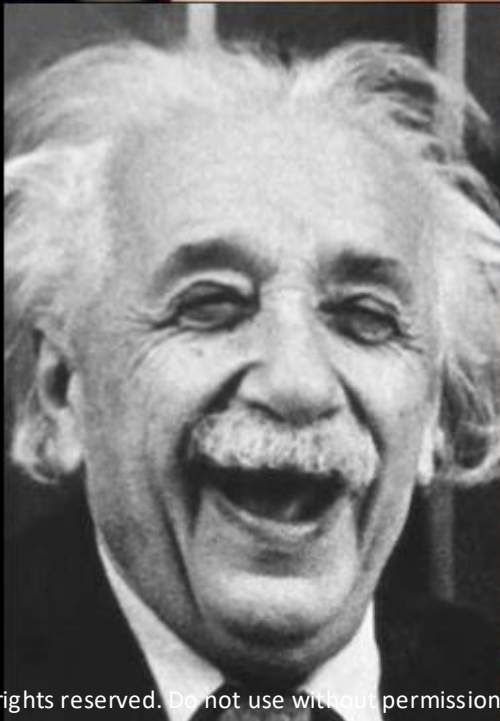
**“We are
here
to build
super-
intelligence”**

An interview
with Sam Altman
on the future
of OpenAI
and ChatGPT

Think:

How can you embellish your text
with relevant metaphors?

Cultural references



To connect with the audience,
infuse your story
with cultural references

Example: Elon Musk's Easter Eggs



2° C



Bjorn



3G



PASSENGER
AIRBAG ON

9:37



Controls

Settings

CHARGING

Suspension

Driving

Cold
Weather

Trips

Displays

E-Brake &
Power Off

DEPTH (LEAGUES)

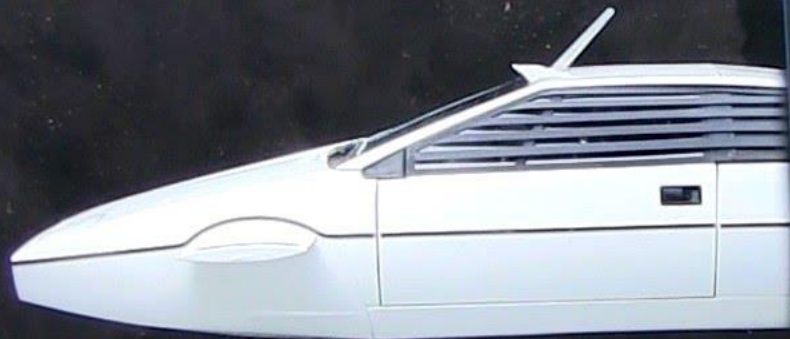
0

2,000

10,000

20,000

JACK



AUTOMATIC LOWERING

ADJUST SPEED

Set to NEVER

Average age of Tesla car
owners at the time? 54

...and 76% are male

Hedges & Company, November 2018



To connect with the audience,
infuse your story
with cultural references
relevant to your audience

Think:
What cultural references
can you leverage
to connect with your audience?

Creative limitation

Details and facts

Mystery Box

Metaphors

Cultural references

Simplicity

Show, don't tell

Interaction

Simplicity

If something
can't be explained on
the back of an envelope,
it's rubbish

Richard Branson



The Flesch-Kincaid readability test

- Developed in 1975 for the US Navy to assess the reading difficulty of technical manuals
- Used today to gauge the appropriate reading level for books used in schools
- Measures word length, sentence length, and other factors to assign a grade level – the number of years of education required for a person to understand a certain text

POWERWALL
TESLA HOME BATTERY

TESLA
ENERGY

POWERWALL
TESLA HOME BATTERY

Welcome everyone to the announcement of Tesla Energy.

What I'm going to talk about tonight is a fundamental transformation of how the world works, about how energy is delivered across Earth.

This is how it is today. It's pretty bad. It sucks.

I just want to be clear because sometimes people are confused about it. This is real.

This is actually how most power is generated, with fossil fuels.

What's the Flesch-Kincaid score here?

Articles from HBR boast a grade level of 17 or higher.

For a text to be read by the general public the grade level should not be higher than 8.

Answer: 6.3

The solution is in two parts.

Part one, the sun.

We have this handy fusion reactor in the sky called the sun.

You don't have to do anything. It just works. It shows up every day and produces ridiculous amounts of power.

Flesch-Kincaid score?

Answer: 2.9

Here's a great example from Shark Tank

Charles Michael Yim, September 2013



Breathometer: the first time in the show's history all five sharks invested, \$200k each.



[Home](#) » [News & Events](#) » [Press Releases](#) » “Breathometer” Marketers Settle FTC Charges of Misrepresenting Ability to Accurately Measure Users’ Blood Alcohol Content

“Breathometer” Marketers Settle FTC Charges of Misrepresenting Ability to Accurately Measure Users’ Blood Alcohol Content

January 23, 2017

Pitched on TV’s “Shark Tank,” the app-supported smartphone devices targeted consumers who wanted to make smart driving decisions after drinking

FOR RELEASE

TAGS: [Bureau of Consumer Protection](#) | [Consumer Protection](#) | [Advertising and Marketing](#) | [Advertising and Marketing Basics](#) | [Health Claims](#)

The marketers of two app-supported smartphone accessories, marketed to accurately measure consumers’ blood alcohol content (BAC), have agreed to settle Federal Trade Commission charges that they lacked scientific evidence to back up their advertising claims.

Under the terms of the [FTC settlement](#), defendants [Breathometer, Inc.](#), and the company’s founder and chief executive officer Charles Michael Yim, are barred from making future accuracy claims for a consumer breathalyzer product unless such claims are supported by rigorous testing. The defendants also are required to notify and pay full refunds to consumers who bought their devices.

“People relied on the defendant’s products to decide whether it was safe to get behind the wheel,” said Jessica Rich, director of the FTC’s Bureau of Consumer Protection. “Overstating the accuracy of the devices was deceptive — and dangerous.”

Think:
How can you simplify your story?

Cut down on fancy words.

Cut lengthy sentences.

Creative limitation

Details and facts

Mystery Box

Metaphors

Cultural references

Simplicity

Show, don't tell

Interaction

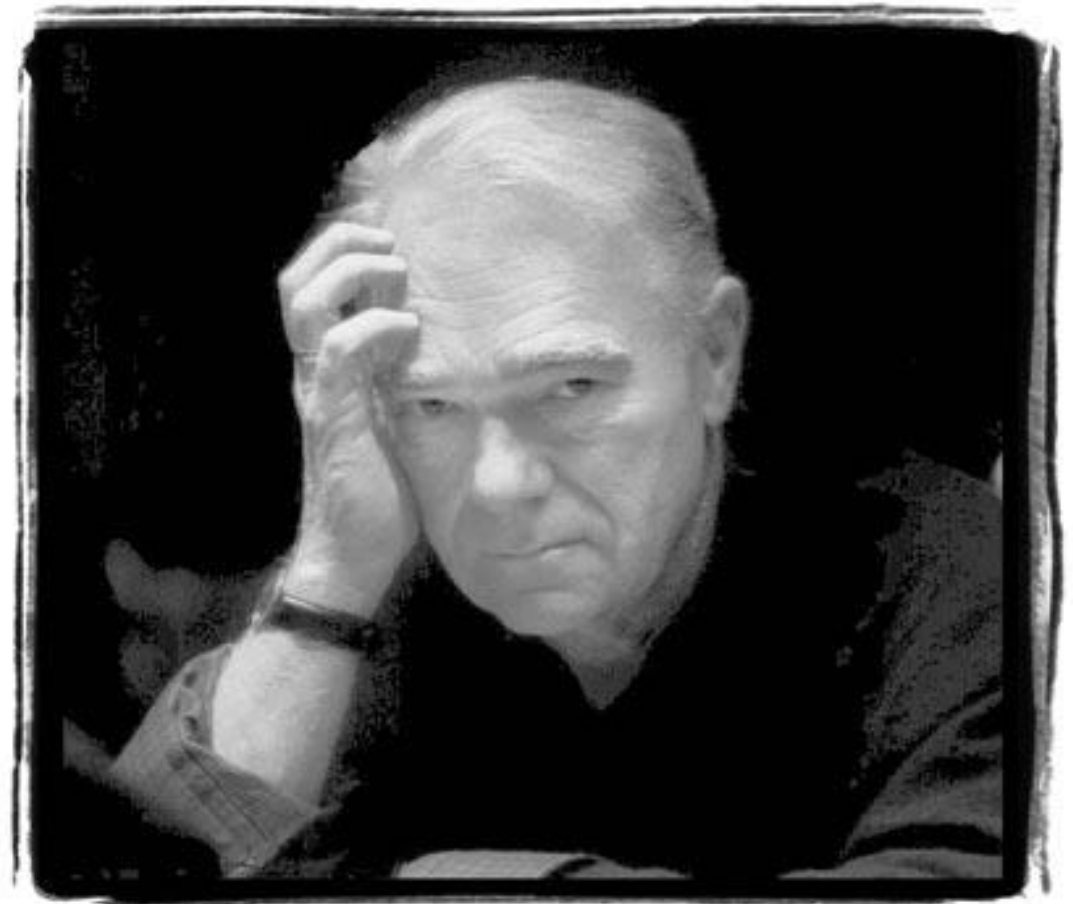
Show, don't tell

Finding Your Scenes and Showing them

Show, Don't Tell & Creative Limitation in Business Storytelling

What Robert McKee teaches us about making stories unforgettable in business:

"True character is revealed in the choices a person makes under pressure."



What Is “Show, Don’t Tell”?

- Telling = stating facts or feelings.
- Showing = dramatizing action and behavior.

McKee Insight: Audiences don’t believe what you say about yourself — they believe what you *do* in a moment of pressure.

What Is “Show, Don’t Tell”?

Example – Telling:

- "I handled the crisis with composure."

Example – Showing:

- "My hand was shaking when I took the mic, but I looked at the team and said, 'We'll take responsibility. We'll fix it. Together.'"

What Is “Show, Don’t Tell”?

Example – Telling:

- "I was scared"

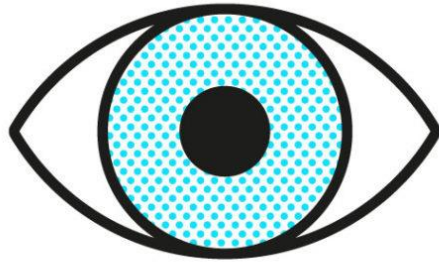
Example – Showing:

- "I reread the email four times, then hit send anyway"

Why Showing Works in Business Settings?

- “Showing” builds **trust**: It makes you authentic.
- “Showing” drives **emotion**: People remember what they feel.
- “Showing” fuels **action**: Clear moments create clear takeaways.

You receive



90%

— OF THE INFORMATION —

VISUAL



Your Brain processes
visual information



60x

— FASTER THAN TEXT —

Here's a nice example of
Show, don't tell



How to show, not tell: A ladder of possibilities

- Do it virtually
 - Use hands to form figures in the air, make comparisons, show size, evoke emotion
 - Use movement (walk, jump, kneel) to show size, evoke emotion
- Use drawings (via a slide, a whiteboard, a flip chart)
- Use real, physical objects
 - Interact with objects in space (sit, kick etc.)
 - Bring forward specific objects that play a part in the story
- Do a real demo [see next slide]
- Interact with the audience
 - Ask questions to probe feelings or discuss action
 - Simulate a dialogue with a member of the audience

The power of a demo: The Twilio example

Post by Fred Wilson, co-founder of Union Square Ventures, an early investor in companies such as Twitter, Tumblr, Zynga, Kickstarter, Etsy and others.



[Archive](#) [About](#) [Subscribe](#) [Twitter](#) [Q](#)

Best Seed Pitch Ever

I read yesterday evening that our portfolio company [Twilio](#), which priced its IPO last night, [is going to live code from the NYSE this morning](#). That brought a powerful flashback to the first time I met [Jeff Lawson](#), founder and CEO of Twilio.

It was 2008 in our old offices on the 14th floor of the building we still work in. My partner Albert, who led our investment in Twilio, had met Jeff and was impressed with him and his vision for Twilio. He asked me if I would meet with him and so I did.

Jeff came into the conference room, sat down, and said “we have taken the entire messy and complex world of telephony and reduced it to five API calls”.

I said “get out of here, that’s impossible.”

Jeff proceeded to reel them off and I said “wow”.

He then pulled out his laptop, fired up an editor, and started live coding an app. He asked me for my cell phone number and within 30 seconds my phone was ringing.

I said “you can stop there. that’s amazing”.

It was, and remains, the best seed pitch I’ve ever gotten. I’ve told him that many times and have told this story many times. I am not sure why it has never made it to this blog. But this morning is a great time for that to happen.

June 23, 2016 – VC & Technology



Think:

What can you **demonstrate**
to the audience, instead of
telling them about it?

Interaction

Can you think of ways to
interact with your audience?

A few common ways to interact with the audience

- Ask questions
- Poll the audience
- Quiz the audience
- Use props
- Call on someone to talk
- Call someone to the stage
- Ask for a volunteer
- Initiate physical activity

Whichever way you choose
to interact – make it relevant

Let's summarize

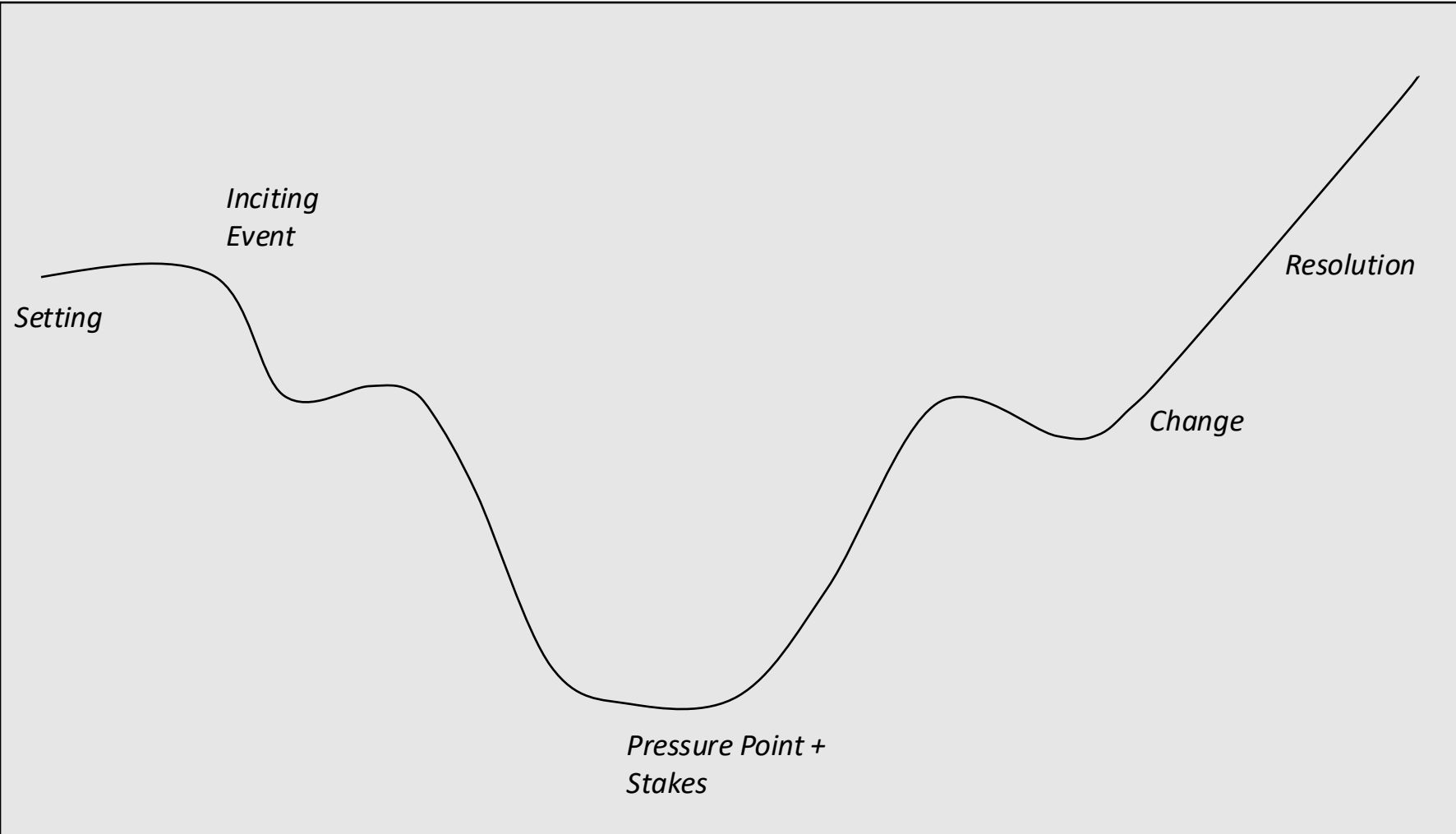
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Antagonist
Conflict



Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

TAKE IT WITH YOU

Creative Storytelling Techniques

Limitations

On which specific moments or situations should you focus?

One specific management discussion, one specific project, one client in one specific situation, one specific sale etc.

Details, facts, anecdotes

Don't talk about a "person" – describe him or her in detail; Don't talk about an event – describe it in detail; Use dialogue when describing an important conversation; Weave facts and figures **seamlessly** into your story.

Mystery Box

Open Gaps of Curiosity: Open with an intriguing statement, Allude to the future, Use superlatives when describing other characters, Add a new character in the middle of the story, Pivot – change direction.

Metaphors

How can you embellish your text with relevant metaphors?

Scarlett is like the sun vs. Scarlett **IS** the sun

Cultural references

What **relevant** cultural references can you leverage to connect with your audience?

Simplicity

Show, don't tell

What can you demonstrate to the audience, instead of telling?

Do it virtually, Use drawings (via a slide/whiteboard/flip chart), Use real physical objects, Do a real demo, Interact with the audience.

Interact

Ask questions, Poll the audience, Quiz the audience, Use props, Call on someone to talk, Call someone to the stage, Ask for a volunteer, Initiate physical activity.

Final Takeaways: Your Checklist for Story Impact

Ask Yourself:

- Did I *show* behavior instead of *telling* traits?
- Did I choose a tight, emotionally charged scene?
- Did I reveal a *choice under pressure*?
- Did the audience *feel something real*?

Final Takeaways: Your Checklist for Story Impact

Bonus Tip: Use this structure:

1. Setup – Where and what's at stake?
2. Scene – Dramatize the moment.
3. Shift – What changed in you?
4. Reflection – What's the takeaway for *them*?

Now, after we've discussed the entire Story Arc Canvas, it's important to identify the differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

What do you think are the major differences?

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose		

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented
Audience		

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented
Audience	Usually mass audience	Specific audience/Individual

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented
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Controlling idea		

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

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Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented
Audience	Usually mass audience	Specific audience/Individual
Controlling idea	Often more than one	One and one only

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	Hollywood	Business world
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Protagonist		

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

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Protagonist	Conscious and unconscious desire	Conscious more conspicuous

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Conflict	Key to the story	Key to the story

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Pressure point		

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Resolution		

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Resolution	Can be happy or sad	Must be positive

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

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Creative limitation		

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Conflict	Key to the story	Key to the story
Pressure point	Towards the end	Has to appear fairly early
Resolution	Can be happy or sad	Must be positive
Creative limitation	Limitations exist – to a limit...	As condensed as possible

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

	Hollywood	Business world
Purpose	Feel-oriented	Do-oriented
Audience	Usually mass audience	Specific audience/Individual
Controlling idea	Often more than one	One and one only
Protagonist	Conscious and unconscious desire	Conscious more conspicuous
Conflict	Key to the story	Key to the story
Pressure point	Towards the end	Has to appear fairly early
Resolution	Can be happy or sad	Must be positive
Creative limitation	Limitations exist – to a limit...	As condensed as possible
Details and facts		

A few differences between Hollywood stories and business world stories

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Mystery box	The gap can stay open	The gap should close
Interaction	No direct interaction	Interaction is critical

But Professor...

Answers to difficult storytelling questions

What if I only have 2 minutes to tell
my story?



What if I only have 2 minutes to tell my story?

- **Make them feel your pain**, transport them to the scene
- **Make them** feel the pain and **see the gain** – the change and the resolution
- Plant a **Mystery Box** so they'll want to hear more

What if I only have 2 minutes to tell my story?

The **shorter time** you have – the longer you'll need to prepare and the clearer you'll have to be about the essentials: controlling idea, conflict and stakes.



Susan Rice's Story

Purpose: WIIFM?

Why I am a diplomat

The Audience:

General Public, Elites

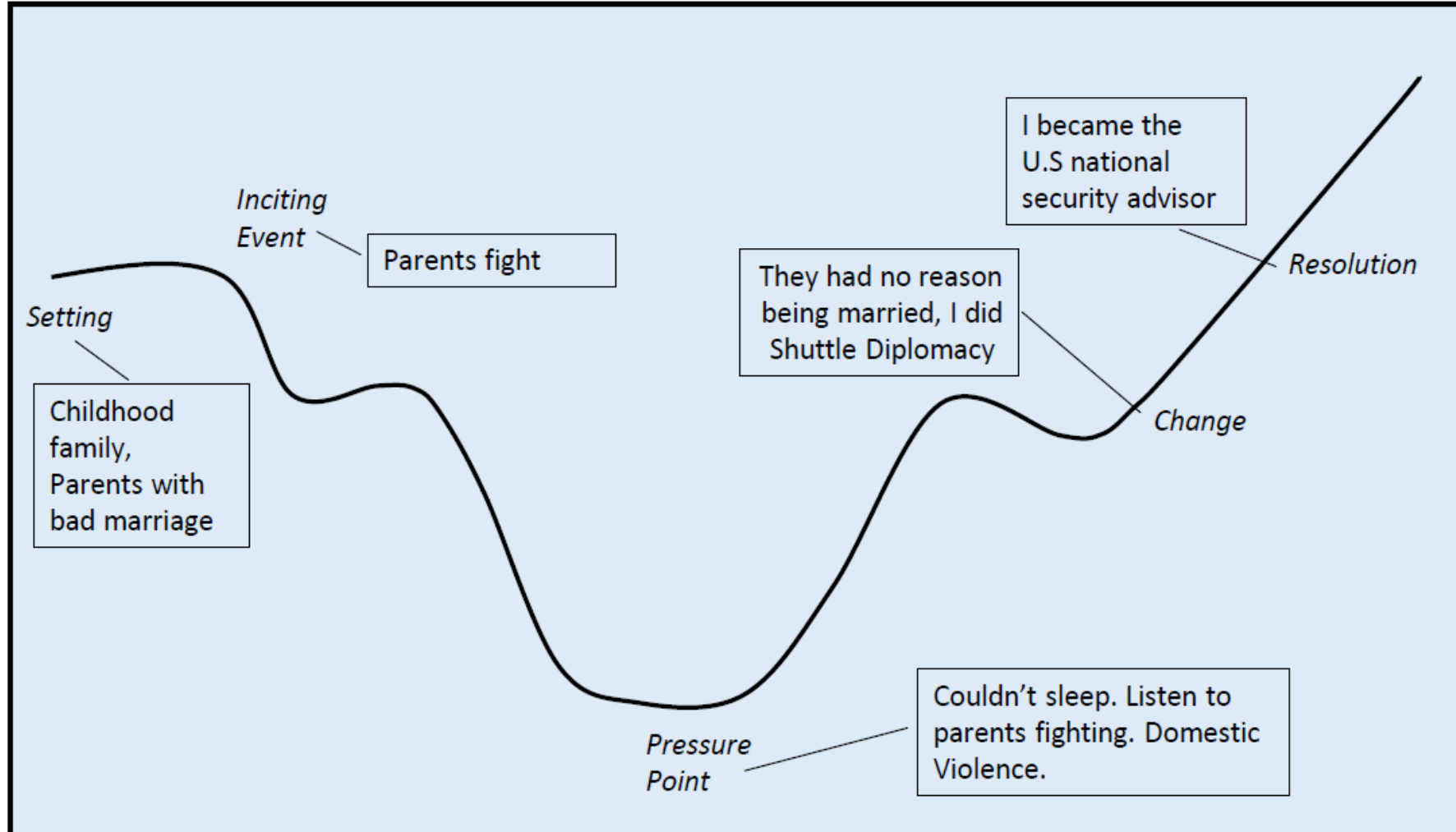
Controlling Idea:

Challenges in childhood
can prepare you for life

Protagonist: Susan Rice

Antagonist: Parents

Conflict: Growing up with
parents that constantly
fight



Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations - I would listen and come and intervene
- ☐ Details and facts
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors - House was a "tinderbox"
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity - Simple
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

What if I don't have time to prepare, and my story is not polished?



What if I don't have time to prepare, and my story is not polished?

- Always be prepared with a few stories “in storage”
- Ask yourself two questions:
 - What do I want them to think about me?
 - What story will demonstrate it to them?
- Lastly, **stories don't have to be “polished”** – they need to be authentic, believable and with purpose

How can I gauge **how long** a story should be?

If you are a speaker – they will tell.

If you are in management – the norms. They tell you.

If you don't know how much time you have – ask and prepare accordingly.

Know your audience and their norms.

Shorter is better – unless you are a master storyteller.

Does every presentation/meeting/speech
need to have a story?

How do I define the purpose of my story?

A close-up of a person's arm and hand reaching upwards, with the index finger pointing towards the word 'story' in the main text. The lighting is dramatic, highlighting the skin against a dark background.

How do I define the purpose of my story?

- Answer the question: **Why do you want to tell a story to that audience?** What's in it for them? What's in it for you?
 - The purpose is that THEY will.....
 - The purpose is that I will....
- What narrative will support the purpose?
 - e.g., “She is the most reliable person”
 - “He will stop at nothing to deliver on his promises”
- What story will demonstrate the narrative?
 - e.g, “How I stayed true to my values”

How do we make sure we're using story responsibly, especially in leadership roles?

What if I don't have a story?

THIS

IS WHO

I AM

What if I don't have a story?

- You always tell a story. Even if you don't say a word
- The only question is: who is controlling your story?

Can you talk about delivery?



Voice: Variety is key

- **Intonation** – change your pitch according to content
- **Diction** – the key to diction is articulation
- **Volume** – modulate volume to convey emotion (soft/loud)
- **Tempo** – slow down to emphasize, and use the power of the pause

And two more:

- Embrace your **accent**
- **Rehearse!** (mirrors are optional)

Body language: Control yourself and the room

- **Movement** [when in a non-virtual environment!]
 - Use the space... but move in moderation (no constant pacing or being stuck in one spot)
 - Don't hang onto the podium; don't fidget
 - Step forward to emphasize; step into the audience to engage and involve
- **Posture**
- **Gestures/Hands**
 - Open up
 - Use your hands to describe

Body language [continued]

- **Facial expressions**
 - Use facial expressions to convey emotion
- **Eyes/Eye contact** [mostly when in a non-virtual environment!]
 - Don't look at the screen behind you – face the audience
 - Scan the room; look at EVERYone
 - If eye contact is a problem, focus on forehead



Can emotional stories serve my
career and business purposes?

Can emotional stories serve my career and business purposes?

- Did you ever make a business decision (hiring, closing deal with a vendor) based on a story that spoke to you?
That was not “by-the-book”, didn’t fit the formal criteria?
- What did you learn about this person that made you want to work with her or recommend her?

I'm not so good with emotions



I'm not so good with emotions

- You don't have to be overly emotional. No need to cry and sob. There's no need for "drama"...
- You can show vulnerability, and talk about failures/flaws/difficulties
- Make people understand or feel the difficulty

How can I become comfortable putting myself in an **insecure or vulnerable position**?

Once you do it again and again in a way that is purposeful – you will see the big upside that you get.

You will see the immediate response of people.

THEY WILL LOVE IT.

(In the fringes some of them will hate it).

How do I know when to show **vulnerability and what specific details** to pull into a story in an interview setting?

Depends on the context and on the time you have.

If it's the first interview and you have 5 minutes the vulnerability has to be limited and it must be weaved into the story in a way that doesn't suck all the attention.

Vulnerability is a fantastic tool to get people's attention, to gain credibility and to make them care. But it must be weaved into a story that powerfully demonstrates your controlling idea.

Use it, but don't turn it into the message of the story.

What if I don't have a big and dramatic story?



What if I don't have a big and dramatic story?

- Find a **small** dramatic story
- **Any difficulty** that you overcame and that changed you, taught you or made you grow **is dramatic!**
- The “smaller” the drama, the more you'll need to use creative techniques

A bright orange arc, resembling a comet or a stylized arc, curves across a dark blue night sky filled with numerous small, distant stars. The arc starts from the bottom left, curves upwards and to the right, and then curves back down towards the right side of the frame.

What if my story doesn't have an Arc?

What if my story doesn't have an Arc?

- Find the conflict, the dilemma, the difficulty, the change, the point you go furthest out of your comfort zone
- There you will find a piece of your Arc

What if I don't have a stage?



What if I don't have a stage?

- Create your stage!
- You don't need to stand in a conference room or in a hall with a podium – every situation can serve as a stage as long as you have a compelling story
- Numerous great elevator pitches were delivered in the back seat of a taxi, on the way to an “actual” meeting

How do I handle a hostile audience?



Handling a hostile audience (before)

- **Prepare** in advance – study the audience and identify, as much as possible, your audience's pre-conceived notions, opinions, biases and beliefs
- **Predict** – anticipate the hostile questions and challenges that might arise due to these biases and beliefs
- **Practice** addressing those challenges

Handling a hostile audience (do's)

- **Define** the playing field – use consensus-oriented statements to establish common ground
- **Dive in** – tackle a controversial subject head-on to create (or diffuse) tension
- **Delay** – promise to get back to the audience with a more thorough reply, or suggest a later context for discussion
- **Disarm** the audience by using humor
- **Draw empathy**, by opening up emotionally
- **Divide and conquer** – talk to the positive people in the room
- **Discuss** – offer the hostile question to the audience
- **Dissent** – agree with the dissenters to surprise and confuse them

Handling a hostile audience (don't's)

- **Don't argue** or try to show the audience how wrong they are
- **Don't get into** lengthy **one-on-one** discussions
- **Don't get angry**

How do I tell a story in a zoom meeting?

1st zoom meeting vs 10th zoom
meeting



How do I tell a story in a zoom meeting?

- Lack of physical contact increases the importance of **a great story**
- People suffer from zoom-fatigue – **hone your delivery** to keep the audience's attention
- Eye-contact is often a challenge – **plan to interact**
- **Fill the screen** and **look into the camera**
- **Avoid background distractions**, unless they support your story

What if I have a story, but it's not about me?

YOU DIDNT COME THIS
FAR TO ONLY COME
THIS FAR

What if I have a story, but it's not about me?

- Who is the protagonist?
- What is your purpose?
- How does the story serve your purpose?
- Tell the story well!

For a story that is worthy of a TEDx talk... any specific recommendations?

- Business people need control, clarity, and persuasion. You design the story so your audience walks away with a specific message.
- But Roland Barthes' idea always haunts the storyteller: you can't guarantee that the message will land exactly as intended.
- That's why businesses' storytellers test messaging, retell, and tailor stories differently for investors, customers, and employees.

For a story that is worthy of a TEDx talk... any specific recommendations?

- We introduced the method → how to structure stories so they're compelling.
- Barthes gives the warning → meaning is never entirely in your control.
- Successful business storytelling engineer structure while anticipating multiple interpretations.

I need to tell a story about the future



I need to tell a story about the future

- Describe the present moment, the current situation, as **the bottom of a painful arc** – make them feel the pain
- Share why it is **crucial** to change the direction
- **Describe the future** that awaits you when you change direction, and how it fulfills your shared “Why”
- Explain why and how **you can make it happen**
- Who is the protagonist? How would telling her story serve your purpose?

What if my story doesn't have a clear resolution?

What if I'm still in the middle of the story?

How do I prevent forgetting parts of my story even after practice?

For people making a big career change,
how can we best tell the story that Booth
changed us?

What are the best practices for editing and improving a draft?

How often do you revisit and update your story?

Final words

Summary

- First, Define Story Structure
- Emphasized Plot Over Character
- Introduce Key Concepts
- Identified Universal Elements of Story
- Laid the Groundwork for Emotional Persuasion

What Aristotle Teaches Us About Storytelling in Business:

1. Start with a clear arc — a beginning, middle, and end.
2. Put action at the center, not just ideas.
3. Reveal your character through tough choices.
4. Emotion persuades more than logic alone.
5. Every scene must change the state of play.
6. Avoid deus ex machina — no miracles or shortcuts.
7. Stick to unity of purpose.
8. Use distinct voices and clear language.
9. Embody universal themes.
10. End with catharsis — a shift in the audience.

Next Steps

1. Identify opportunities
2. Practice
3. Feedback
4. Learning
5. Impact
6. Sharing

...and they lived
happily ever after

